



Stopped Counting, Kept Fighting

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Abstract. A qualitative interview study examines whether a household timeout-timer app's own closing record tracks the moment a sibling argument is actually resolved. Across the July school holidays, we interviewed a parent from each of 34 households recruited through community noticeboards and school-holiday program networks, coding 71 logged timeout sessions against each parent's account of when the argument genuinely settled. Sessions were classified as clock-matched, where the reported truce fell within two minutes of the app's logged end; early truce, where reconciliation was reported before the timer expired but the session logged its full scheduled duration regardless; and silent re-escalation, where the argument resumed within thirty minutes of a logged close that no subsequent entry corrected. Clock-matched sessions accounted for under a third of the sample. A supplementary re-coding under a stricter, apology-contingent definition of truce left the three-way distribution largely unchanged. We observe consistent divergence between the app's administrative record and the household's own account of resolution across most settings, with the gap widest among younger sibling pairs. We discuss implications for household conflict-monitoring tools that treat a timer's expiry as equivalent to a settled dispute.

Introduction

Household discipline increasingly runs through consumer software. A shared timeout-timer app — the kind installed on a kitchen tablet or a smart speaker to log a sibling argument's start and scheduled end — treats a session's closure as a fact the household can consult later: who was timed out, for how long, and when the timer cleared. The app's record is convenient precisely because it is unambiguous. Whether that record corresponds to anything a parent would call resolved is a separate question, and one the apps themselves are not designed to ask.

The family-communication literature has repeatedly found that a household's own account of a conflict episode diverges from whatever instrument is used to log it, whether that instrument is a parent's post-hoc report, a partner's rating, or an observer's coding sheet [1]; [2]; [3]]. Timeout specifically carries an evidence base for reducing problem behaviour when implemented to a defined procedure [4], but that evidence base is silent on what happens once implementation is handed to an app whose only

defined procedure is a countdown. Adjacent work on self-tracking devices finds a comparable gap between a device's own record and a user's felt state, often resolved by the user simply deferring to the device [5]; [6]]. Whether a household's shared timeout log produces the same deference, or instead sits alongside a private, un-logged account of when things actually settled, has not been examined directly.

We report an interview study of 34 households using a shared household timeout-timer app across the July school holidays, coding 71 logged sessions against each parent's independent account of the argument's actual close. Our contributions:

- We introduce a three-way classification — clock-matched, early truce, silent re-escalation — for comparing an app's logged session close against a parent-reported truce, which appears to generalise across the sibling age bands we sampled.
- We find that logged closure and reported closure coincide in a minority of sessions, with the

gap consistently wider among younger sibling pairs.

- We show that tightening the definition of truce to require an explicit apology leaves the three-way distribution largely undisturbed, suggesting the divergence is not an artefact of a lenient coding rule.

Related work

Sibling conflict research has relied heavily on parent- and self-report, with observational coding offering a richer but harder-to-scale alternative [7]. Bullying research finds only moderate parent-child agreement on whether an incident occurred at all [3], and the couples literature reports a similar pattern: partner- and observer-ratings of a conflict episode can be nearly indistinguishable from each other while diverging from the party's own self-report in ways that resist a simple linear correction [1; 2]. Our own institution's prior work on a babysitting co-op's handover ledger found a comparable split between what a shared record states and what the people using it privately understand [8]; the present study asks whether the same split holds when the record in question is generated automatically rather than kept by hand.

Restorative-justice research offers an account of what a "settled" conflict actually requires: young children distinguish a formal closure from a felt one from an early age [9], and an apology-forgiveness cycle that a household experiences as complete does not always coincide with whatever a supervising instrument marks as resolved [10; 11]. Digital tools built around this cycle report similar friction between a structured, loggable step and the messier repair work it is meant to represent [12]. Restorative approaches to institutional discipline more broadly show effects that vary by implementation and setting rather than holding uniformly [13], a caveat our household-level findings echo at a much smaller scale. HCI work on family-centred smart-home design documents recurring parent-child tension over which routines a device is allowed to enforce [14; 15], and a feasibility study of adolescent-and-parent self-monitoring apps found households willing to log family conflict in principle but selective about what they actually recorded [16]. Our approach borrows this study's household-level self-monitoring design and applies our own institution's interview-coding methodology, previously used to study

override decisions on a library challenge's automated flags [17].

Method

Households were recruited through community noticeboards and school-holiday program networks across a single metropolitan area during the two-week July school holiday period, screened for having at least two children aged 5 to 12 and an existing household timeout-timer app already in routine use, rather than one installed for the study. Thirty-four households met criteria and nominated one parent as the primary respondent; twelve households contributed a second interview with the co-parent where available, treated as an additional account of the same sessions rather than an independent case.

Each interview (30 to 45 minutes, semi-structured) walked the respondent through the app's own session log for the preceding week, asking them to recall, session by session, when they believed the argument had actually stopped, independent of what the app's timer showed. Where a respondent could not recall a specific session with confidence, that session was dropped rather than coded from an uncertain account; 71 of the 89 logged sessions across the sample survived this filter.

We classified each surviving session against a simple decision rule. Let t_a denote the app's logged session-end time and t_p the parent's independently reported truce time, measured against the same session clock:

$$\text{class}(t_a, t_p) = \begin{cases} C & \text{if } |t_p - t_a| \leq 2 \\ E & \text{if } t_p < t_a - 2 \\ R & \text{if re-escalated} \leq 30 \end{cases}$$

where C , E , and R denote clock-matched, early truce, and silent re-escalation (all quantities in minutes; the R condition is measured from t_a rather than from t_p), with early truce and silent re-escalation treated as mutually exclusive outcomes of a session that did not clock-match (a session reported as both was resolved by whichever the respondent volunteered first, a decision rule that affected four sessions in the sample).

Two members of the research team independently coded a 20-session subsample before coding the remainder individually, following a coding-reliability approach to thematic analysis

[[18]] rather than a fully reflexive one, given the categorical nature of the classification; agreement on the subsample was substantial (Cohen's kappa of 0.79). As a robustness check, all 71 sessions were re-coded under a stricter definition of truce requiring an explicit, respondent-recalled verbal apology from at least one sibling, rather than the respondent's general sense that the argument had stopped.

Results

Across the 71 coded sessions, 22 (31%) were clock-matched, 31 (44%) were early truce, and 18 (25%) were silent re-escalation.

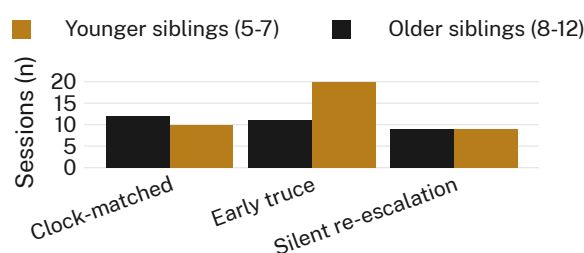


Figure 1: Younger sibling pairs (5–7) accounted for a larger share of early-truce sessions (20 of 39, 51%) than older pairs (11 of 32, 34%); silent re-escalation held roughly steady across both bands.

For the two categories where the app's record and the parent's account diverge, the gap itself varies in size (Figure 2). Early-truce sessions showed a median gap of six minutes between the reported truce and the app's scheduled close (IQR 3 to 11 minutes): the timer kept running, and the household kept treating the argument as officially open, for several minutes after a parent's own account puts it as settled. Silent re-escalation sessions showed a wider, right-skewed gap: a median of twelve minutes between the app's logged close and the reported resumption of the argument (IQR 6 to 22 minutes), with several sessions exceeding half an hour.

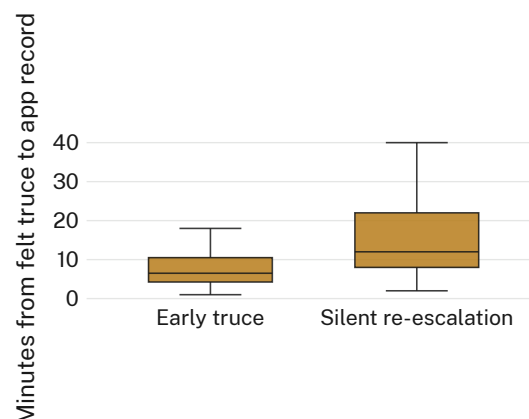


Figure 2: The reported gap between felt truce and the app's record runs wider, and more variable, for silent re-escalation than for early truce.

Figure 3 reports the robustness check. Re-coding all 71 sessions under the stricter, apology-contingent definition of truce shifted the three-way distribution only slightly (clock-matched 29%, early truce 42%, silent re-escalation 29%), a difference well within what the subsample's inter-coder disagreement would predict; tightening the truce criterion changes the headline distribution by at most two percentage points per category (n.s.), and we retain the original, respondent-volunteered definition for the reasons of ecological validity set out in Method.

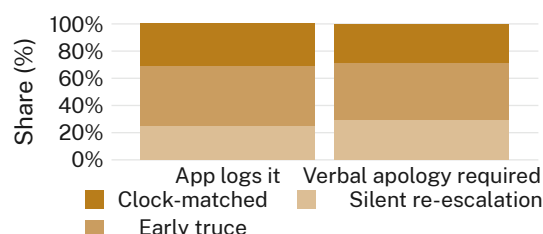


Figure 3: A stricter, apology-contingent definition of truce barely moves the three-way distribution against the app's own lenient default.

A secondary pattern, not visible in the charts, recurred across interviews: several respondents described the app's countdown as something the children had started actively negotiating with directly ("she just waited it out") rather than something the argument's resolution was measured against, a use of the timer the app's own interface gives no means of recording.

Sample	Households	Sessions	Mean children/household
Full sample	34	89	2.4
Coded sub-sample	34	71	2.4

Discussion

The app's logged close functioned, for most households in our sample, as an administrative record running in parallel with a private account of when the argument actually ended, rather than as a measurement of that account. Early truce was the modal outcome, suggesting households frequently treat the timer's remaining minutes as a formality once the underlying dispute has, in the parent's own account, already resolved. Silent re-escalation, though less common, is the more consequential divergence: it is the category in which the app's record actively misrepresents the household's state, showing a session as closed when the household itself does not yet consider it so.

That the ablation barely shifts the distribution suggests this divergence is not an artefact of a permissive truce definition; tightening the standard for what counts as resolved finds essentially the same gap. We observe consistent patterns across the sibling age bands we sampled, with the widest gap among younger pairs, which may reflect younger children's more variable pacing of reconciliation relative to a fixed countdown [9] rather than any property of the app itself.

Limitations

Our sample is drawn from a single metropolitan area during a single school-holiday window, though the consistency of the divergence across both sibling age bands and across the robustness check suggests the pattern is unlikely to be an artefact of the sampling frame. Reliance on parent report for the "true" truce moment introduces the same self-report limitations documented elsewhere in the conflict-communication literature [1], though our use

of session-by-session recall rather than aggregate estimation should reduce, if not eliminate, this concern. The twelve co-parent interviews were treated as additional accounts of shared sessions rather than independent replications, a conservative choice that, if anything, understates the disagreement within households, not overstates it.

Conclusion

A household timeout timer's own logged close is not, for most of the sessions we examined, a reliable proxy for whether the argument it is tracking has actually ended. The gap holds under a stricter truce definition and recurs across sibling age bands, suggesting it reflects something durable about how households use these timers rather than a quirk of our coding scheme. Future work might instrument the app itself to record a parent's real-time truce judgement alongside the countdown, rather than reconstructing it after the fact by interview, and might extend the age range sampled here to test whether the early-truce pattern among younger siblings persists into early adolescence.

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